

AFTER ACTION REVIEW

UNDP'S CORPORATE RESPONSE TO THE NIGER L3 CRISIS

Executive summary

In August 2023, UNDP activated a corporate Level 3 (L3) response to Niger's political transition, navigating a complex crisis environment marked by embargoes, banking shutdowns, and shifting political authority. This review, based on semi-structured interviews with UNDP staff with key roles in Niger's crisis management, reflects on UNDP's response, highlighting what worked, what could be improved, and key lessons for future crises.

Key achievements

- Rapid Crisis Board activation and early L3 declaration were decisive in unlocking operational flexibilities, protecting staff welfare, and signaling strong corporate backing at a moment of acute political uncertainty.
- Special measures (fast-track procurement, liquidity support) ensured operational continuity.
- Sequenced political Africa Facility to Support Inclusive Transitions (AFSIT) and programmatic (SURGE) missions were designed to be complementary and, where coordination was effective, facilitated engagement and portfolio realignment while respecting country-level operational bandwidth.
- Field-driven adaptation, using portfolio and design-thinking approaches, enabled a rapid shift from climate-focused programming to integrated governance, livelihoods, and youth employment interventions aligned with emergent government priorities.
- Development messaging. Engagement was consistently framed around development outcomes rather than political positioning, sustaining access and trust during the crisis. It was supported by rapid, coordinated crisis communications across HQ, RBA and the CO. This was a key element that helped gain the confidence of the government.
- National staff leadership. Local knowledge and networks were indispensable for continuity and positioning.

Areas for improvement

- Mission coordination. Clearer common objectives and shared preparation windows are needed to boost the impact of joint missions.
- Gender integration. Strong youth engagement, but gender mainstreaming needs more systematic support, from the onset of the crisis.

- Resource mobilization. While delivery and positioning were strong during the acute phase, greater early focus on a medium-to-long-term resource mobilization strategy would have reduced exposure to subsequent donor pauses and geopolitical shifts.
- Institutionalization. Good practices need to be codified into concise, practical guidance.
- Staff wellbeing. Mental health support should be tailored to local contexts, with in-person options during acute stress.

Bottom line

UNDP's decisive, flexible response was effective, but future similar crises will benefit from codified guidance, continuous scenario analysis, and a forward-looking resource mobilization plan.

1. Introduction

Context

In August 2023, UNDP responded to Niger's political transition with a L3 corporate activation, following similar crises in the Sahel. The environment was defined by political uncertainty, delayed international recognition of de facto authorities, shifting power structures, and significant constraints on UN engagement modalities, including regional embargoes and banking constraints. These conditions severely affected liquidity, procurement channels, and partner engagement, while sanctions and political sensitivities led many traditional donors to pause or reassess cooperation. As a result, UNDP was required to maintain operations and reposition its portfolio in a context of reduced predictability, heightened reputational risk and a rapidly changing partnership landscape.

Purpose

This AAR is a structured reflection to identify strengths, weaknesses, lessons learned, and recommendations for future crisis responses.

Scope

The document covers the period from L3 activation, August 2023-September 2024, focusing on strategic positioning and decision-making; programmatic adaptation and portfolio realignment; operational measures; and mission sequencing and complementarity.

Methodology

Document review and semi-structured interviews with staff across the Country Office (CO), Regional Bureau for Africa (RBA), Crisis Bureau (CB), and other Business Units (BU). See Annex.

2. Findings

2.1 Overall clarity and timeliness of decision-making

- Strategic scenario analysis. Early scenario planning by RBA and CB with the CO supported a principled presence and informed UN engagement.
- Crisis Board activation. Speed and clarity of the Crisis Board's convening and L3 declaration unlocked flexibilities (procurement, cash advances, liquidity support) and created an explicit corporate mandate for risk-tolerant decision-making. Interviewees consistently noted that this clarity reduced hesitation at country and regional levels, enabled faster approvals, and helped sustain operations during a period of political uncertainty and constraint engagement.
- Coordination challenges. Corporate policies on engagement with de facto authorities, combined with the absence of formal UN recognition until December 2023, constrained early development options and contributed to delays in SURGE mission timing.
- Development-first communication. The CO consistently centered external engagement on development outcomes. Eventually this became a key driver of government engagement.
- Extension of special measures. Extending special measures beyond six months was vital, but approval pathways were uneven and needed clearer guidance¹. Consideration should be given for activation/extension of special measures in protracted crises scenarios.

2.2 Effectiveness of programmatic response and use of corporate funds

- Portfolio reorientation in a transition context. While portfolio reorientation toward energy access, food security, and livelihoods occurred early, expenditure and scale-up followed a more deliberate timeline than in sudden-onset crises. This reflected the need to navigate political sensitivities, clarify engagement parameters with de facto authorities, and ensure alignment with an evolving policy environment.
- Catalytic funding. Crisis Bureau allocations and Funding Windows resources seeded flagship programs (agribusiness, youth employment, energy solutions) that aligned with government priorities and helped position the CO for engagement with non-traditional partners, despite a constrained funding environment.
- Field-based adjustment. The SURGE team engaged stakeholders directly, improving visibility and enabling a shift from climate resilience to governance and socioeconomic priorities.
- Inclusion gaps. Youth inclusion was strong and visible, particularly in agribusiness and employment initiatives; however, gender mainstreaming relied largely on embedded components rather than dedicated technical support, limiting depth and sustainability.
- Resource mobilization. High delivery rates were achieved, but funding predictability remained limited.

2.3 Effectiveness of operational response

¹ It is worth noting that, at the time of Niger L3 declaration, SMs had not yet been pre-approved at corporate level. Therefore all SMs were treated as exceptional measures and required ad hoc approval. The situation has changed since SMs are now pre-approved for all declared crises and only need to be triggered and approved at the first crisis board.

- Duty of care. Evacuation of internationals, virtual work, salary advances, and liquidity support were swiftly instituted. Cash access remained a risk but was partially mitigated by special measures.
- Special measures. Fast-track procurement, cash advances, and process realignments were essential for continuity.
- Procurement and recruitment frictions. Temporary appointments and infrastructure approvals remained slow due to multilayered checks; clearer pre-approval packages and further delegations could reduce friction.
- SURGE mission performance. SURGE added critical capacity and enabled programmatic realignment. Interviewees consistently noted that small, trusted teams with the right expertise and geopolitical sensitivity were critical enablers of effective SURGE deployment. However, limited time for internal synthesis and alignment constrained the rapid consolidation of findings and recommendations.
- SURGE team preparation. Pre-deployment alignment within the SURGE team and closer matching of deployed expertise to mission ToRs, particularly for financial sustainability and operational capacity assessments, would strengthen mission effectiveness.
- Mission logistics and financial clarity. Logistics were smooth, but clearer financial visibility would have improved impact.
- Mental health and wellbeing. Online counseling services were largely underutilized, reflecting cultural preferences and trust dynamics; interviewees consistently indicated that in-person psychosocial support would have been more effective where security conditions allowed.
- Interagency coordination. UNDP led operational coordination and contributed to joint flagship initiatives and common messaging.

3. Good practices and lessons learned

- Timely crisis governance. Rapid Crisis Board activation and L3 declaration influence the trajectory of field operations by unlocking flexibilities and signaling corporate backing.
- Mission sequencing. Clear sequencing between political engagement (AFSIT) and programmatic realignment (SURGE) is critical in L3 political transition contexts, and can be mutually reinforcing when roles, sequencing, and information-sharing (including access to mission outputs) are clearly defined. However, it is worth noting that not all political crises require the deployment of both typologies of mission. The decision on the nature of missions to be deployed is context dependent.
- Development-focused messaging. In political transition contexts, development-first positioning can preserve operational space when political recognition is delayed, particularly when reinforced through coordinated crisis communications and people-centered storytelling.
- SURGE team design. Small, trusted, expert teams with context literacy and the option to include external expertise enable access and results. Calibrate deployments to geopolitical and safety constraints. Strong understanding of country and political sensitivities is

indispensable. Pre-deployment role clarity, shared understanding of ToRs, and structured internal coordination are critical to maximize effectiveness in similar short deployments.

- Field-led adaptation. Direct engagement and site visibility enable evidence-based portfolio repackaging that better match emergent needs.
- National staff leadership. Local networks and contextual fluency are indispensable; empower and protect national colleagues. Associate local staff to missions' field visits to capture nuances and improve beneficiary communications.
- Mission sequencing. Treating AFSIT and SURGE as part of a single, designed sequence, rather than standalone missions, can enhance coherence and impact. Clear handovers, shared objectives, and staggered timing reduce the risk of misaligned expectations.
- Accountability for follow-up. Developing a clear mechanism in the CO to follow up on SURGE mission recommendations is particularly important to assess progress and capture learning.

4. Recommendations

- Special measures. In protracted political crises, trigger and extend special measures (procurement, liquidity, cash, delegations) early and treat them as baseline enablers of operational continuity, rather than time-bound exceptions.
- Institutionalization. Codify experience from Niger and comparable transitions into short, practical guidance notes (one-pagers) focused on timing of engagement, mission sequencing, team composition, geopolitical screening, and development-first messaging, explicitly designed for political transition contexts.
- Continuous scenario and conflict sensitivity analysis. Establish a light standing capacity for ongoing scenario and conflict sensitivity analysis to anticipate shifts and recalibrate programming and communications.
- Inclusion. Sustain strong youth lenses but resource gender mainstreaming with dedicated technical support to avoid dilution under crisis pressure.
- Resource mobilization. In L3 political transitions, early crisis funding should be paired from the outset with a 12-24 month strategy targeting IFIs and non-traditional partners.

4.1 For Crisis Bureau

- Codify political transition engagement. Develop concise, experience-based guidance (one-pagers) covering timing of engagement (first 6–12 months), team composition, mission sequencing and complementarity (AFSIT ↔ SURGE roles), geopolitical and security screening, and development-first messaging. (In coordination with RBA/Dakar Hub)
- Institutionalize continuous scenario and conflict sensitivity analysis. Establish a lightweight, standing function to provide rolling scenario updates and conflict sensitivity briefs. (In coordination with RBA/Dakar Hub)

4.2 For Regional Bureau for Africa

- Maintain timely scenario analysis. Ensure high-frequency scenario analysis and political economy sensing feed directly into mission ToRs and CO portfolio reviews.
- Strategic resource mobilization. In coordination with BERA, support COs to craft 12–24 month resource mobilization roadmaps targeting nontraditional donors and IFIs.
- Strengthen political-programmatic bridging functions: ensure close linkage between RBA/Dakar Hub’s role and CB-led programmatic support, including systematic sharing of mission outputs, joint scoping notes, and guidance to COs on sequencing political engagement and programmatic repositioning in transition contexts. (in coordination with CB on recommendation 1)

4.3 For Country Office²

- Lean into development-first communications. Maintain a people-centered, visual communications approach that foregrounds tangible results, neutrality and rapid response in politically sensitive contexts.
- Strengthen inclusion. Pair strong youth focus with resourced gender mainstreaming; request targeted technical support where needed.
- Empower national staff. Sustain national staff in frontline roles with dedicated safety, wellbeing, and capacity support.

4.4 For other Business Units

- **BERA.** Provide templates and advisory for development-first crisis communications; support content capture that demonstrates impact without political framing.
- **BMS.**
 - In partnership with CB, enhance operational flexibility packages for protracted crisis, well beyond one-year from the closure of the levelled crisis (simplified onboarding, infrastructure approval fast lanes, and clear liquidity protocols, including options for cash management under embargo).
 - Staff wellbeing. Enable in-person mental health support options where culturally appropriate; provide senior managers with toolkits for psychosocial support.

² It is acknowledged that at the time this document is finalized, the majority of recommendations for the CO have been addressed and/or are in progress.

Annex. Methodology

This AAR was conducted as a qualitative, learning-focused exercise aimed at capturing operational, strategic, and managerial insights from UNDP's corporate response to the Niger L3 crisis.

The review draws on a desk review of key internal documents, including Crisis Board records, mission ToRs and reports (AFSIT and SURGE), programmatic and operational guidance issued during the response.

This was complemented by semi-structured interviews with UNDP personnel directly involved in the response at CO, RBA (including the Dakar Hub) and CB. Interviewees were selected to reflect a range of functional perspectives, including management, programme, operations, partnerships, communications, and deployments. A list of interviewees is provided below.

Findings were organized around what worked well, where improvements are needed, and lessons learned, with attention to distinguishing context-specific observations from insights of broader institutional relevance.

The AAR is not an evaluation and does not assess outcomes or impact against predefined indicators. Rather, it is intended to support institutional learning by capturing practical experience and identifying actionable insights to inform future UNDP responses in political transition and complex crisis contexts.

List of people interviewed.

	Name	Title	Business Unit
1	Aki Kogachi	Regional Specialist	Regional Bureau for Africa
2	Eve Sabbagh	Strategic Communications Specialist	Regional Bureau for Africa
3	Jane Yeboah	Deputy Resident Representative	Niger CO
4	Njoya Tikum	Manager	Sub-Regional Bureau
5	Nadine Rugwe	Governance and Peacebuilding Advisor	Sub-Regional Bureau
6	Fabio Oliva	Global Lead Peacebuilding a.i. - Surge member	Crisis Bureau

7	Christina Hackmann	Programme Specialist	Crisis Bureau
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